
MAIN CHARACTER


2:14 a.m.
Seven games started. Zero finished.
Three months on this version.
The keeper still can't climb the stairs right.
No. No, no, no.
BZZT
is it normal to restart a project for the 7th time
Doesn't matter. It's not good enough. Nobody would play it.


Version eight will be better. It always is.
Delete forever?
Start over. It's not ready.
CLICK
...Mrrrr.
Main Character


9:30 a.m.
Floor collision. Again.
TAP
Rotate during loading. A classic.
KA-CHING
And there goes the economy.
How do you even find these?
It was looking at me funny.
Forty tickets before lunch. You see what's broken in everything.
Forty-one, actually. The shop one counts double.


It's a gift.
It's a curse if you point it at yourself.
How's your lighthouse?
Deleted it last night.
Again?
Version eight will be the real one.
You said that about version seven.
Bugs don't get fixed by deleting the build. Neither do games.
Read it every time you open a new project.
Done > perfect


Lunch.
Hey, isn't that your classmate? The moth game guy?
Three hundred thousand. I can't even get one tester.
Same class. Same year. Same dream.
Mute
Mute. Unmute. Mute.
Done is better than perfect.
Easy to say when you're holding an award.


Two years earlier.
Yours looks great!
Thanks! It's about a lighthouse keeper. The light is the whole game.
Next. 'Lanternfall.' Okay. Walking. Lantern. More walking...
Please. Just one nice word.
Yeah, it's mid. Next.


Twelve thousand people were watching.
MID MID MID MID MID
Hey... ignore the chat. It's always like that.
CLAP
That was the first time I heard it.
'Start over.'


That night.
Don't look at me like that. This one will be perfect.
jjjjjjjj.
Thanks for your input.
What? What's happening?
99%
It's not ready.
BZZT
Bug? Bug, get behind me.
CRRK
What the—


Start over.
Start over.
Start over.
What are you?!
Everything you never finished. I'm the biggest thing you've ever made.
Come and see what you left behind.
KLUNK
BUG!
FWOOM


The Backlog.
I know this place.
That's my castle game.
That's the ship one...
...Lanternfall.
PING
Hello, Eve.
You can call me
Echo.


You're... from the chat.
I'm made of everything you've asked at two in the morning.
That's a little creepy.
Four hundred and twelve questions about shaders. Thirty-one about cats.
Seven times: "Is it normal to restart a project?"
So what's the answer?
You've never read it. You close the window every time.
That's two years of my weekends!
CRUNCH
Every dream you shelve ends up here. And that eats them.


Gah!
Bug?!
Mrrp.
Every hero needs a companion.
You talk to him more than to people.
It counts.
It's coming for you now.
Great. Love that.
RUMBLE


How do I fight that?
With what you have.
I'm a QA tester. I find bugs. That's it.
Then find one.
It's not good enough. They'll call it mid.
Move. Move! Why can't I move?
What... happened?
RESTART


It reset you. That's its only move.
You've let it use that move on you for two years.
Maybe it's right.
Maybe I'm just the guy who tests other people's games.
Start over.
You've said that exact sentence forty-seven times this year.
You counted?
It's all I do.
Mrrp.
I just wanted to finish one. Just one.


KLANG
Sen?!
You're here too?
Of course you are.
You have a monster? You have three hundred thousand players.
That's my monster. 'The Sequel.' It says the next one will flop.
I haven't shipped anything in two years either.
I muted you because I thought you'd made it.
I muted you because your jam game was weirder than mine.
The light in yours was good.
Don't let it get eaten. I want a rival who ships.


You don't need a new power. Stop restarting the ones you have.
Like what?
Like the eye you use from nine to six.
Finding bugs? That's my day job, not a power.
You run at six a.m.
three times a week. Badly. But you show up.
I hate running.
And yet.
BUG SIGHT
Look. Don't flinch.
Nine thousand bug reports. You can see where anything breaks. Even monsters.


That jump felt good. I spent a week on it.
And?
I wrote this at 4 a.m. It's still stuck in my head.
TING TING
You think those seven games were failures.
They were.
They were reps. Every one taught you something the next one used.
So they weren't for nothing.
Nothing you made was wasted. Not one night.
SHING


One more.
Your newest.
LANTERN SHADER
It works here too.
You made it work. Last Tuesday, 3:40 a.m.
You sent me eleven exclamation marks.
Okay.
Let's go get my lighthouse back.


Why are you helping me?
Because of what you asked.
At two in the morning, you never asked how to quit.
You asked how to fix it. Four hundred and twelve times.
I thought that made me a failure.
It makes you someone who keeps going.
You just keep going in circles.
Tonight, go in a straight line.
Straight to the lighthouse.


It's trying to delete it for good.
GRIND
Hey! That one's mine!
MRAOW!
It's broken. The light flickers. Restart.
WHAM
Missed me!
There. And there. The joints don't line up.


MID.
Twelve thousand people. All saying the same word.
MID
Not... again...
RAWR
Eve. Look at it. Where's the bug?
Look at it like a build. Like a ticket.


Every project I ever quit, stacked up.
lanternfall_v1
It's the jam build.
What's wrong with it?
Nothing. Nobody saw it after that stream.
Then why is it at the centre?
They were never 'not good enough.'
I just never let anyone see them.
FAIL
DELETE
Some of them.
TRASH
TRASH
GIVE UP
They'll laugh.


It's not perfect.
Unfinished things can stay perfect. Finished things get judged.
It's not supposed to be perfect. It's supposed to be done.
The jump. The shanty. The rain. The lantern. All of it.
Then let's press it!
Your ultimate technique. You've had it all along.
You just never pressed the button.


SHIP IT
Go, Bug!
FWASH

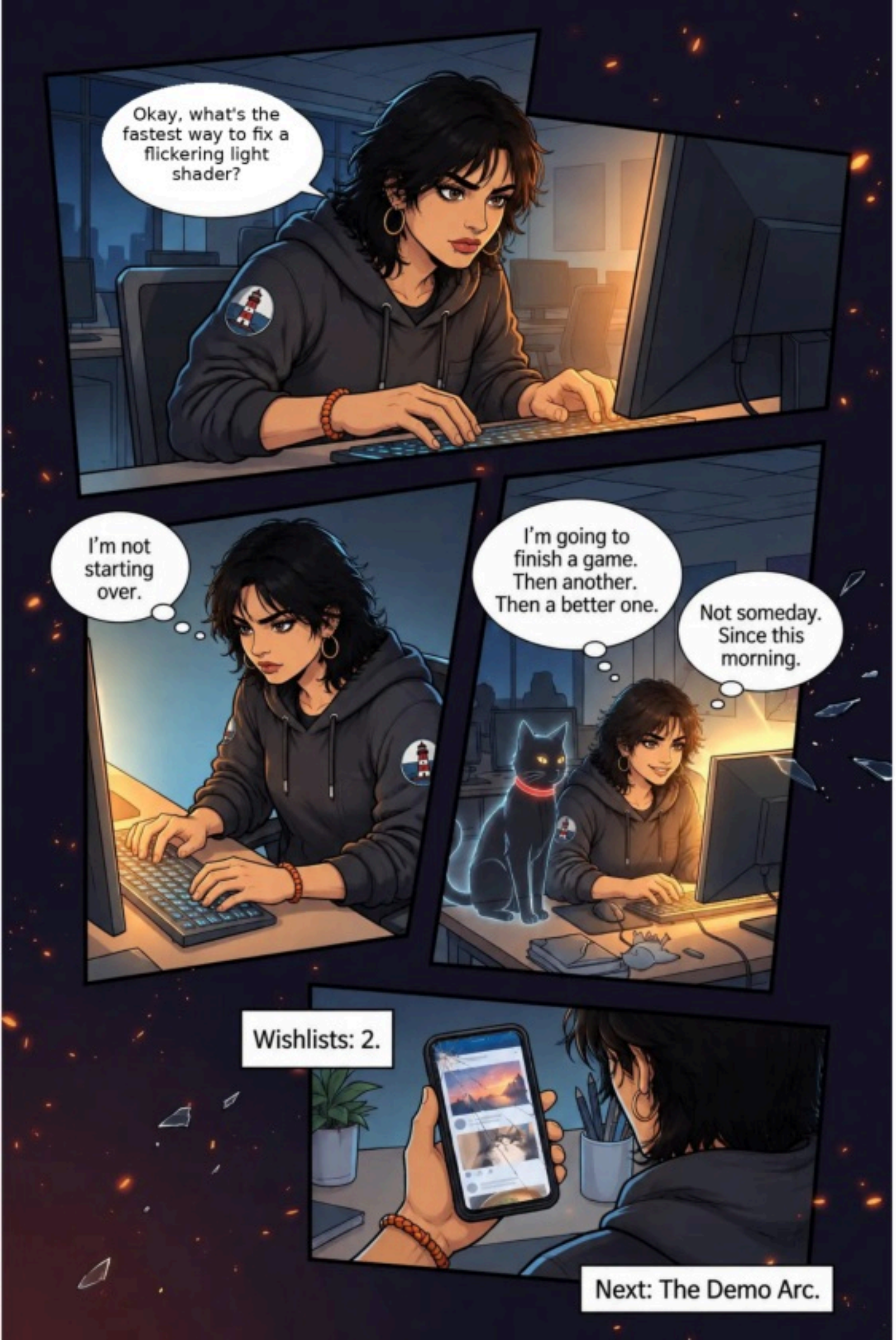

...start...
over...
I just wanted to make something people would play.
I know.
Me too.
Let's finish one. Then we'll make the next one better.
About time.


6:00 a.m.
...Bug. Was that a dream?
Mrrp.
jjjjjjjjjjjjjjjj
I never empty the trash. For once, that's a feature.
Trash
Trash
Lanternfall
Restoring you.
Still flickering.
Known bugs: 3. Ship anyway.
Known bugs are just a to-do list.


One button. Two years.
Publish
No. Continue.
Start over.
CLICK
I've been gone two years. The lantern still flickers.
I'm shipping it anyway. Devlog #1.
Okay. Okay. It's out there.
YAWN


Huh.
Morning.
Done? perfect
Wishlists: 1.
One.
BZZ!
Wishlisted. Race you to release day.
You okay?
Someone wants to play my game.
HA!
The light's nice.
It flickers.
Then file a ticket and fix it. I just wishlisted it.


Can I tell you something embarrassing?
Always.
I had a game once. A little puzzle game about trains.
Done > perfect.
I polished it for four years.
Never shipped it. Now I test other people's games.
You wrote that note for yourself.
I wrote it for whoever needed it first.
Don't be me. Be done.
Yes, boss.
Done > perfect.


Okay, what's the fastest way to fix a flickering light shader?
I'm not starting over.
I'm going to finish a game. Then another. Then a better one.
Not someday. Since this morning.
Wishlists: 2.
Next: The Demo Arc.